

A heap queue or priority queue is a data structure that allows us to quickly access the smallest (min-heap) or largest (max-heap) element. A heap is typically implemented as a binary tree, where each parent node's value is smaller (for a min-heap) or larger (for a max-heap) than its children. However, in Python, heaps are usually implemented as min-heaps which means the smallest element is always at the root of the tree, making it easy to access.

heapq module allows us to treat a [list](#) as a heap, providing efficient methods for adding and removing elements.